

Gates Mocks \$100 Laptop

Bill Gates has mocked Nicholas Negroponte's \$100 Linux-based, wind-up powered laptop: "Geez, get a decent computer where you can actually read the text, and you're not sitting there cranking the thing while you're trying to type." Gates says cell phones are what will popularise computing in developing nations.



Wire-Free And Free

Skype is going wireless! Netgear plans to soon introduce a Wi-Fi phone that can handle Skype calls from any wireless hotspot. Developers for Skype are also working on new versions of their software that can work on the OSes of regular cell phones.



Enter

Shahrukh Khan

Actor

Self-confessed geek, The Khan hardly needs introduction.

How much do you surf?

I'm not a "casual surfer"—I don't surf for the sake of surfing. At the point where it just started out, when we had telephone lines and the strange sounds—that was the time I was excited about surfing. Now I just use it for research.

What are your favourite gadgets?

I always roam around with a couple of laptops, and I always have a digital camera—stuff which I normally use. The whole idea of gadgets, I think, has been demystified by the laptop—you just need to have one and everything is at your beck and call.

Do you tinker with video editing?

I do edit my home videos, but very, very slowly. I won't get a job as an editor, but I do know my way around Final Cut Pro and use it quite often.

Do you think it's time for movies to be shot in the Digital Video (DV) format?

No, I really don't. I think we still need the grainy quality that film cameras give us. I'm not questioning movies like *The Phantom Menace*—I think it's outstanding—but as a film viewer, I wouldn't want to watch something that's so... bland.

Gaming?

I play games with my kids, hardly on my own. We have a PS2 and an Xbox, and we are waiting for the PS3 to release.

HOPPING ON THE BANDWAGON

Intel To Debut Ultra-Cheap PC

Chipmaker Intel will soon pitch a very low-cost PC at the developing world. The proposed machine will be priced at "meaningfully lower" than \$300, and an announcement should follow in some weeks, according to William Siu, Vice President and General Manager of the Channel Platforms Group at Intel.

In an interview with CRN (Channel REseller News), Siu said the proposed system would provide full PC functionality to "take advantage of all the software and content" on the Internet. Past attempts to develop a \$100 PC have "missed the point,"

according to Siu: he said they're too limited and that they can't be loaded with extra software. Siu claimed they're more like PDAs than PCs.

Remember AMD's PIC—the Personal Internet Communicator? It was launched back in 2004, and the specs went AMD Geode GX500 CPU, 128 MB of memory, a 10 GB hard disk and an inbuilt modem—running

Windows CE. The idea was to bring Internet access to much of the third world. There are suppliers in several countries for the PIC, but the PIC hasn't been too much in the news after its launch.

Better known than the PIC is, of course, Nicholas Negroponte's \$100 laptop. The One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) organisation hopes to have it out late this year or early next year. It has had more than its fair share of criticism, and we'll have to wait to see if the project does deliver even a laptop per 10 children.

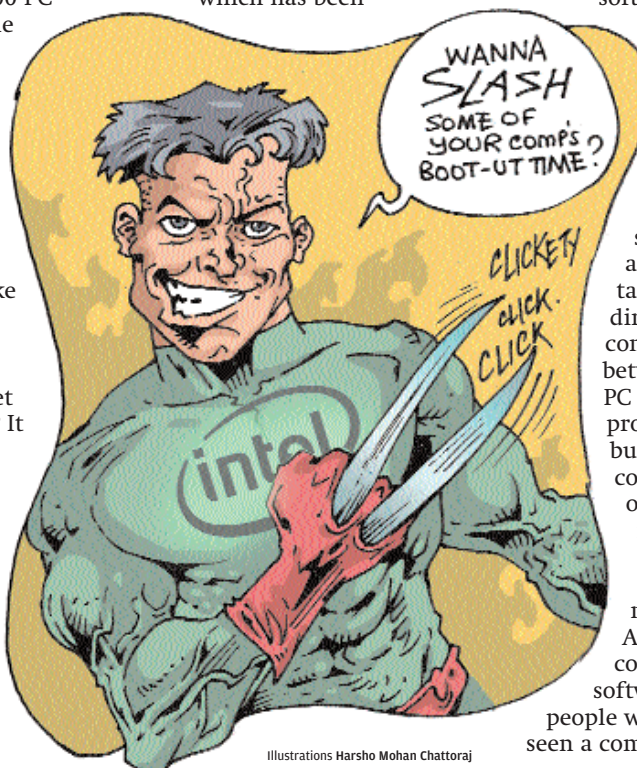
Then, of course, we have our home-grown Simputer, which has been

around for a long while now—too long, actually: it's always waiting to take off. Other flopped attempts have been made in the past, as well, to bring "low-cost computing to the masses,"—the much-banded phrase. But will Intel go where no company has gone before?

"The purpose of owning a PC is to be able to access content and to utilise the software available out there," said Siu. "So giving me a product that is under-served does not address the reason why you want to even own the product... what I've described is a full-function PC that can take advantage of all the

software and content."

In the rural Indian context, \$100 (Rs 4,500) and, say, \$250 (Rs 11,000) are significantly far apart. We're not talking about a direct competition between the \$100 PC and Intel's proposed offering, but it comes to content, what our villages need is basic connectivity, not streaming multimedia. And when it comes to software, are people who haven't ever seen a computer likely to



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatterraj